

# Activating products or problems?

Windows Product Activation is the latest implementation by Microsoft against software piracy. **Vidyaramanan S.** speaks with industry representatives to gauge if it will be a success

The underlying principles of Microsoft's software licensing policy have not changed. Microsoft's End User License Agreement (EULA) has always stipulated the number of PCs that software can be installed on, and this remains the case for Windows Product Activation (WPA) as well.

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while building the WPA technology. Under WPA, no personally identifiable information is collected.

Product Activation is not a single 'silver bullet' solution to global piracy and is not designed to target sophisticated and organised criminal counterfeiters. It is aimed at countering casual copying by ensuring that the copy of the software product is installed on a PC in compliance with the EULA.

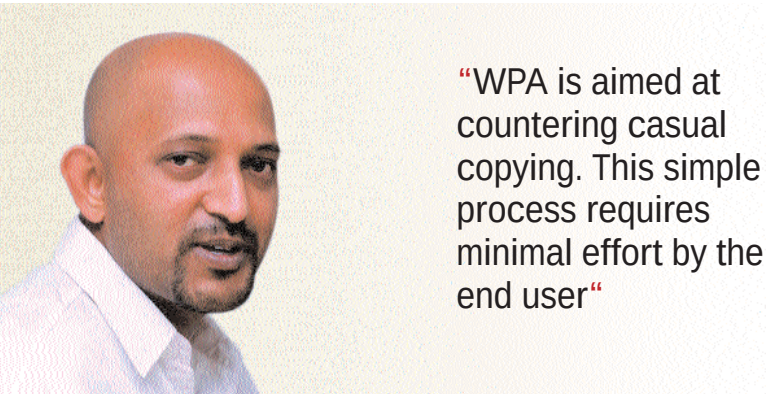
Kudos to WPA! The blue screen of death is now going to be succeeded by Windows Product Activation (WPA) as the most annoying experience. Most anti-piracy schemes end up causing problems rather than aiding the consumer and preventing piracy. Microsoft's WPA scheme is also headed the same way. Software hackers and pirates will always find a way to crack the encryption schemes used to protect software.

installation, you might end up in quite a tug of war on installing a RAM module or a new graphics card.

Piracy is a big threat to any software company and Microsoft is trying to defend itself by introducing WPA. But it will cause unnecessary hassles right from getting the product registered and all along the

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"WPA is aimed at countering casual copying. This simple process requires minimal effort by the end user"



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WPA can tolerate a certain degree of change in hardware configuration, which allows users to change their hardware without the software believing it is on a different PC from the one it was activated on. However, if the hardware is substantially different, reactivation may be required. Reactivation in this case, is easy and can be completed by contacting a Microsoft customer service representative to obtain another confirmation ID.

Microsoft gives increasing importance to protecting customers' privacy and user privacy was a paramount design goal

The process for Product Activation is a simple four-step procedure that requires minimal effort by the end user—there is no reason a genuine customer should find it tedious. It is unobtrusive, significantly more sophisticated than past methods and is not easy for would-be pirates to circumvent.

Additionally, we have tested this technology with our Indian customers with the launch of Office XP, where the product activation system allows a user to install a copy of Windows XP only on one computer, and haven't received any negative feedback from them. ■

Activation can be done via the Internet or the phone. For this, Microsoft's activation servers will have to be accessible round the clock. Nothing could be more annoying than getting a cryptic error without competent help at hand. And if you choose to activate the product over a toll free number, you would have to read out the key on the CD or the accompanying pamphlet and there is enough room for confusion while doing so. A simple mistake would force you to go through the process all over again. Though Microsoft claims that minor upgrades will not require you to re-activate the

course of its use. Every time you re-activate your installation, you have to contact Microsoft. Yes, no private information is transferred but it also means that any time Microsoft decides not to support XP, you could be left in the lurch. Corporate customers are in a two-year loop—why not the same for the retail customers?

People are too comfortable with Windows, which is why Microsoft is not too worried about a mass defection to other OSs. The way I see things, eventually people will upgrade to XP, experience the annoyance named WPA, sigh and go on. ■

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Karthik Padmanabhan November 10 at 4 p.m.

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